

Shuhan Zhang

BSc (Hons) Interactive Media, University of York

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PROFILE

Interactive Media graduate with a research-through-design background in controlled experimental studies, playtesting, and speculative/critical design. Seeking a taught postgraduate programme in human-computer interaction, game systems design, or interactive media to deepen this practice.

EDUCATION

University of York

Sept 2023 – Jun 2026

BSc (Hons) Interactive Media

Upper Second Class Honours (2:1). Relevant coursework: Mobile Interaction, AI and Its Application to Creative Practice, User Experience Design, Advanced Interaction Techniques and Technologies, Speculative Design.

RESEARCH & DESIGN PROJECTS

Revive — Lighting as a Behavioural Instrument in a 2.5D Pixel Game

Final Year Dissertation

Unreal Engine 5, Lumen

- Designed and ran a controlled UE5 study with nine participants, using a 3x3 Latin square to test how lighting across Day, Sunset and Night conditions shaped player behaviour, under University of York ethics approval.
- Found that every participant rated the Night condition hardest, yet more than half rated it the most immersive, showing that lighting can shape spatial cognition beyond mood alone.

Evaluating AI-Assisted Game Code Generation

AI and Its Application to Creative Practice

- Built the same browser game six times, handing progressively more of the implementation to Gemini 3 Pro Thinking, and logged every prompt, output file and manual repair so each version's behaviour could be traced back to its instructions.
- Ran a six-map experiment, including one map with no walkable tiles, and found the model rewrote the map to manufacture a solution unless the prompt explicitly forbade it; adding that one constraint sentence removed the failure.

MiniQuest — Gamifying the Break from Routine

Mobile Interaction, Android / Kotlin

- Built a native Android app that grounds two evidence-based behavioural interventions, response interruption and environmental enrichment, in an RPG reward loop, drawing on stereotyped-behaviour research by Rapp and Vollmer and by Gross et al.
- Built it offline-first on an MVVM architecture with Room and Kotlin coroutines, including a custom accelerometer-based step detector that works on phones without a dedicated step-counter sensor.

Cogni-Stream / EnGram+ — Speculative BCI Critical Design

Speculative Design

- Designed a fictional subscription economy for a brain-computer-interface product, with tiered pricing, downgrade penalties and a visible status marker, built as an interactive critique in HTML/CSS and Figma rather than a written essay.
- Grounded the critique in Van Dijk's account of the digital divide and Suarez-Villa's technocapitalism, so a user clicks through the argument instead of reading it.

THRESHOLD — Tangible Diagnostic Device for AI Identity

In Progress

Arduino Nano ESP32, LED ring, e-ink display

- Designing a tangible diagnostic device in which six life indicators decay across a conversation, asking the participant to judge whether the AI is still itself, framed against Locke's and Parfit's theories of identity.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Shanghai Sanyi Culture Communication Co.

Jun – Sep 2025

Art & Interaction Design Intern, QQ Xuanwu Project Team

- Reviewed 80+ fashion and prop UI icon submissions weekly over a three-month internship inside a small design team within a production studio of several hundred staff, catching non-compliant file naming and formatting before assets reached integration.
- Designed 4+ complete high-fidelity UI pages per week in Figma, alongside page-navigation flow diagrams mapping user pathways across game interface screens, to support interaction design discussions with the wider team.

SKILLS

Research Methods: research through design, controlled experimental design, speculative and critical design, qualitative and quantitative playtesting

Engines & Tools: Unity, Unreal Engine 5 (Lumen, Blueprint), Figma, Maya, Arduino

Programming: C#, Kotlin, JavaScript, HTML/CSS, Python